

Session 26: The Rulers Above

Key Takeaways

- The sun, moon, and stars of Genesis 1 are heavenly beings.
- Heavenly beings are called “signs” (Gen. 1:14) because they are symbols of the true source of light.
- Heavenly beings form God’s divine council, his staff team who are under his divine command.
- The word “angel” in the New Testament broadly means “heavenly being,” and these beings often look like people.

The Host of Heaven

In Genesis 1, the “host of heaven” are set in the “sky-dome” (Gen. 1:14-18). They are the inhabitants of the divine throne room above the heavens. This helps us understand why the biblical authors consistently use the language of stars to describe spiritual beings. They inhabit the heavenly realm and have authority under God. The host of heaven are the staff team of God’s heavenly throne.

Psalm 103:19-21 NIV*

¹⁹ The LORD has established his **throne in heaven**,
and his kingdom rules over all.

²⁰ Praise the LORD, you his **angels**,
you mighty ones who do his bidding,
who obey his word.

²¹ Praise the LORD, all his **hosts of heaven**,
you his servants who do his will.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Kings 22:19 NASB*

Micaiah said, “Therefore, hear the word of the LORD. I saw the LORD sitting on his throne, and all the **hosts of heaven** standing by him on his right and on his left.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 148:1b-3 NIV*

¹ Praise the LORD from the heavens;
praise him in the heights above.

² Praise him, all his angels;
praise him, all his **heavenly hosts**.

³ Praise him, sun and moon;
praise him, all you **shining stars**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Luke 2:9, 13 NASB

⁹ And an angel of the Lord suddenly stood before them, and the glory of the Lord shone around them; and they were terribly frightened. ... ¹³ And suddenly there appeared with the angel a multitude of the host of the heavens praising God ...

Observations on the Phrase “Host of Heaven”

The lists of heavenly creatures in [Psalms 103](#) and [148](#) are in the literary form of Hebrew parallelism, paired lines that describe the same things from different points of view. The heavenly hosts are the sun, moon, and stars.

Notice how in [Luke 2](#), the angel is associated with the light of God’s glory, and these two are associated with the host of heavens, who are depicted as God’s heavenly choir (as they are in [Job 38:7](#) and [Isa. 6:1-3](#)).

The Sons of God

Job 38:4-5, 7 NASB*

⁴ Where were you when I laid the foundations of the land?
Tell me if you have understanding.
⁵ Who set its measurements? Since you know.
Or who stretched a measuring line over it? ...
⁷ When the **stars of the morning** sang together
and all **the sons of God** shouted aloud.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 89:5-8 NASB*

⁵ The heavens will praise your wonders, O LORD;
your faithfulness also in **the assembly of the holy ones**.
⁶ For who in the skies is comparable to the LORD?
Who among **the sons of God** is like the LORD,
⁷ a God greatly feared in **the council of the holy ones**,
and awesome above all those who are around him?
⁸ O LORD God of hosts, who is like you, O mighty LORD?
Your faithfulness also surrounds you.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

These are parallel lines in Hebrew, which means that the stars and the sons of God are not separate entities but the same creature described from two perspectives.

- Day four of creation delegates the “host of heaven” as authorities (Gen. 1:14-19)

- Stars as signs of spiritual beings (Job 38:4-7)
- Stars are “in the sky-dome” and images of the divine council
- Passages about God among the council/hosts (Ps. 82:1, 89:5-7; Isa. 24:21-23; Ps. 148:1-6)

Throughout the Story of Israel, the People Continually Worship the Stars as Deities

Deuteronomy 4:19 ESV*

And beware lest you raise your eyes to heaven and when you see **the sun and the moon and the stars, all the host of heaven**, you be drawn away and bow down to them and serve them, things that the LORD your God has allotted to all the peoples under the whole heaven.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Amos 5:25-27 ESV*

²⁵ “Did you bring to me sacrifices and offerings during the forty years in the wilderness, O house of Israel?

²⁶ You shall take up Sikkuth your king, and Kiyyun **your star-god—your images that you made for yourselves**, ²⁷ and I will send you into exile beyond Damascus,” says the LORD, whose name is the God of hosts.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Zephaniah 1:4-5 NASB*

⁴ I will stretch out my hand against Judah and against all the inhabitants of Jerusalem. And I will cut off from this place the remnant of Baal and the name of the idolatrous priests along with the priests, ⁵ **those who bow down on the roofs to the host of the heavens**, those who bow down and swear to the Lord and yet swear by Milcom ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Book Recommendation

[*Angels: What the Bible Really Says About God's Heavenly Host*](#) by Michael S. Heiser.

Reflection Question

In this session on heavenly beings, what ideas are most significant for you?